

SRI VAISHNAVA DOSSIER: BATCH 2

(CORE AZHWARS)

BATCH EXECUTIVE SUMMARY TABLE

Personality Name	Tamil Month / Nakshatram	Avathara Sthalam (Birthplace)	Divine Amsam	Primary Literary / Philosophical Contribution
Nammalwar	Vaikasi / Visakam	Thirukkurugur (Alwarthirunagari)	Vishvaksena (Chief of Divine Hosts / Commander of Lord Narayana)	<i>Tiruvaymoli</i> (1102 Pasurams), <i>Thiruviruttam</i> (100 Pasurams), <i>Thiruvasiriyam</i> (7 Pasurams), <i>Periya Thiruvanthadhi</i> (87 Pasurams); Formulated the core Viśiṣṭādvaita framework (Dravida Vedam).
Madhurakavi Azhwar	Chittirai / Chithirai	Thirukkolor	Kumuda (Divine Garland/Attendant)	<i>Kanninun Siruthambu</i> (11 Pasurams); Established <i>Acharya Abhimana Valli</i> / <i>Acharya Bhakti</i> (Total Surrender to the Preceptor) as the supreme

				means to salvation.
Kulasekara Azhwar	Masi / Punarvasu	Thiruvanchikul am (Kodungallur, Kerala)	Kaustubham (Divine Gem) / Koustubha-Am sam / Divine Bow (Sarnga)	<i>Perumal Thiruvanthadhi / Perumal Thirumozhi</i> (105 Pasurams) in Tamil, and <i>Mukundamala</i> (40 Slokas) in Sanskrit; Exemplified intense <i>Rama Bhakti</i> , <i>Vatsalya Bhakti</i> , and total detachment from royalty (<i>Vairagya</i>).

1. NAMMALWAR

(Shatagopan, Maran, Parankusan, Vakula Bhushana, Kurugai Piran, Dravida Vedakara)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Nammalwar (literally "Our Own Azhwar," a name lovingly bestowed by Lord Ranganatha), Shatagopan, Maran, Parankusan, Vakula Bhushana, Kurugai Piran, Sri Shatagopa Muni, Vedam Tamil Seitha Maran.
- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Vaikasi (Vaikasi Visakam)
 - **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Visakam
 - **Tithi & Paksham:** Vaisakha Sukla Purnima (Kali Yuga onset era; traditionally 3102 BCE, modern academic scholarship places him c. 8th–9th Century CE).
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Thirukkurugur (on the banks of the Tamraparni River)
 - **Current District & State:** Alwarthirunagari, Thoothukudi District, Tamil Nadu.
 - **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Adinathar Temple, Alwarthirunagari (Thirukkurugur) & Nava Tirupathi network.
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**

- **Divine Amsam:** Vishvaksena (The Chief Commander of Sriman Narayana's divine forces/hosts).
- **Historical Period:** Early Medieval / Pandya Dynasty era (c. 8th–9th Century CE).
- **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Madhurakavi Azhwar (His foremost disciple and recorder), Pandya Dynasty Rulers of Southern Tamilakam.

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Miraculous Incarnation:** Born to Kariyar (Local Chieftain of Thirukkurugur) and Udayanangai without taking material breath or crying (*Ayoni-like* untouched state) → **The Shatagopa Manifestation:** Overcoming the binding cosmic wind *Shatam* and earning the name *Shatagopan* → **The Sixteen-Year Silent Meditation:** Sitting motionless inside the hollow of the sacred Tamarind Tree (*Thirupuli*) at Adinathar Temple without food or speech → **Encounter with Madhurakavi:** Responding to Madhurakavi Azhwar's profound riddle (*Sethiyin Vayil Siriyathu Pirandhal...*) with eternal Vedantic truth → **Outpouring of Dravida Veda:** Composition of four monumental Prabandhams corresponding to the four Sanskrit Vedas → **Ascension to Vaikuntham:** Physical transformation and merging into Sriman Narayana at the age of thirty-five.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born into a noble Vellala family in Thirukkurugur, the infant exhibited extraordinary divine characteristics from the moment of birth. Unlike ordinary mortals who cry upon birth due to the touch of *Shatam*—the cosmic wind of delusion that erases prior divine memory—this divine child completely subdued the wind, earning the eternal name **Shatagopan**. The child took no physical nourishment, did not cry, and remained completely unattached to physical surroundings. Distressed yet awestruck, his parents Kariyar and Udayanangai brought the infant to the shrine of Lord Adinathar in Thirukkurugur. The child crawled into the hollow of a sacred, ancient tamarind tree (*Thirupuli*) within the temple precinct, assumed the *Padmasana* posture, closed his eyes, and remained in uninterrupted *Samadhi* (divine trance) for sixteen full years.
- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** His primary *kainkaryam* was the revelation of the highest Vedantic doctrines through the sweet Tamil tongue. Without traveling physically from his station beneath the Tamarind Tree, he experienced direct, uninterrupted vision (*Prathyaksha Anubhava*) of Lord Narayana presiding across all 108 Divya Desams.
- **Miracles & Historical Events:**
 1. *The Thirupuli Samadhi:* For sixteen years, Nammalwar remained in the hollow of the Tamarind Tree without food, water, or human interaction, completely absorbed in the inner vision of Para Vasudeva. The leaf of this sacred tree never slept (*Urangappuli*), reflecting its master's eternal vigilance in divine contemplation.
 2. *The Awakening by Madhurakavi:* Madhurakavi, an elder scholar-pilgrim traveling in North India, noticed a dazzling, unnatural beam of light shining continuously toward the south. Following this light across thousands of miles, he arrived at Thirukkurugur and discovered the glowing youth seated inside the Tamarind Tree. To test whether the youth possessed physical consciousness, Madhurakavi dropped a heavy stone nearby; Nammalwar

opened his eyes. Madhurakavi then posed a famous philosophical riddle: *"If a tiny entity is born inside a dead body/substance, what will it eat, and where will it abide?"* (Sethiyin Vayil Siriyathu Pirandhal Etthai Thindru Enge Kidakkum?). Nammalwar broke his sixteen-year silence and delivered his first immortal words: *"It will eat that, and it will abide there!"* (Atthai Thindru Angge Kidakkum!). The profound inner meaning—that the individual soul (*Jiva*), when bound within the inert physical body (*Prakriti/Pina*), experiences and abides in material sensations, but when anchored in God, feeds solely on God—instantly made Madhurakavi his lifelong disciple.

3. **The Sanga Phalakai Miracle:** When scholars of the Madurai Tamil Sangam questioned the validity of Nammalwar's Tamil verses, Madhurakavi placed a small leaf containing the single line *"Kannan Kazhalgalinaai"* (The twin lotus feet of Lord Krishna) on the divine Sangam plank (*Sanga Phalakai*). The miraculous plank instantly threw off all other manuscripts and held only Nammalwar's verse, forcing the Sangam poets to acknowledge his supreme authority.
- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Nammalwar is revered as the primary **Prapanna Jana Kootastha**—the spiritual progenitor and root Acharya for all Sri Vaishnavas. Madhurakavi Azhwar stood as his foremost disciple, serving as his scribe and chronicler.
- **Attainment of Paramapadam:** At the young age of thirty-five, having rendered the essential import of the Upanishads into Tamil, Nammalwar absorbed his physical form into the supreme luminosity (*Param Jyothi*) of Lord Adinathar, ascending to Sri Vaikuntham.

💡 **Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: Thirupuli & Prapanna Kootastha**

The sacred Tamarind tree (*Thirupuli*) at Alwarthirunagari is regarded as an incarnation of Adishesha himself, providing shade and protection to Nammalwar. Nammalwar is designated *Prapanna Jana Kootastha* because all subsequent Acharyas—including Nathamuni, Yamunacharya, and Ramanuja—trace their spiritual authority and Sri Vaishnava lineage (*Guru Parampara*) directly back to him.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works:**
 - *Tiruvaymoli* (1102 Pasurams) – Corresponding to the **Sama Veda**; the pinnacle of Dravida Vedam.
 - *Thiruviruttam* (100 Pasurams) – Corresponding to the **Rig Veda**.
 - *Thiruvasiriyam* (7 Pasurams) – Corresponding to the **Yajur Veda**.
 - *Periya Thiruvanthadhi* (87 Pasurams) – Corresponding to the **Atharva Veda**.
- **Quantified Output:** 1296 Pasurams total across four major Prabandhams.
- **Associated Divya Desams (Mangalasasanam):** Glorified 36 major Divya Desams including Alwarthirunagari, Thiruvengadam (Tirupati), Sri Rangam, Thirukudanthai, Thiruvallavazh, Thirukannapuram, Thirumoolikkalam, and Paramapadam.
- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Formulated the four pillars of Dravida Vedam. His works provided the core textual foundation upon which Sri Nathamuni later recovered the entire *Naalayira Divya Prabandham* through intense yoga and *Upadesha* from Nammalwar in a divine vision.
- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core: Nayaka-Nayaki Bhava** (Bridal

Mysticism, assuming the persona of *Parankusa Nayaki*) and **Artha Panchakam** (The Five Cosmic Truths: Tattva, Svarupa, Hita, Purushartha, and Virodhi). His core doctrine centers on *Saranagati* (Absolute Unconditional Surrender) at the feet of Sriman Narayana.

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Tiruvaymoli, Decad 1.1, Pasuram 1 (*Uyarvara Uyarsulum*)

Text Layer	Content
Original Script (<i>Tamil</i>)	உயர்வர உயர்நலம் உடையவன் எவனவன் மயர்வற மதிநலம் அருளினன் எவனவன் அயர்வறும் அமரர்கள் அதிபதி எவனவன் துயரறு சுடரடி தொழுதெழு என்மனனே
Roman Transliteration	<i>Uyarvara uyarnalam udaiyavan evanavan</i> <i>Mayarvara madinalam arulinan evanavan</i> <i>Ayarvarum amarargal adhipathi evanavan</i> <i>Thuyararu sudaradi thozhuthezhu enmanane</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Uyarvara: Unsurpassed/Supreme above all; Uyar nalam: highest glorious attributes/goodness; Udaiyavan: He who possesses; Evanavan: He who is that Supreme Lord; Mayarvara: freeing from delusion/ignorance; Madi nalam: enlightened wisdom infused with devotion (<i>Bhakti-roopa-jnana</i>); Arulinan: He who mercifully bestowed; Evanavan: He who is that Supreme Being; Ayarvarum: free from forgetfulness/slumber; Amarargal: eternal celestial beings (<i>Nityasuris</i>); Adhipathi: the supreme Sovereign/Lord; Evanavan: He

	who is that Lord; Thuyararu: destroying all sorrow/affliction; Sudar adi: His radiant lotus feet; Thozhuthezh: worship and rise up in service; En manane: Oh my mind!
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Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

- Esoteric Meaning (Swaroop Jnanam):** This iconic opening verse of *Tiruvaymoli* encapsulates the entire Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy. It addresses the mind (*En Manane*), commanding it to surrender to the Supreme Lord who possesses infinite auspicious qualities (*Ananta Kalyana Guna*), who bestows delusion-free wisdom (*Mayarvara Madinalam*), and who rules over the eternal celestials (*Nityasuris*).
- Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Establishes the three core doctrines of Vedantic thought:
 - Para Tattva*: Sriman Narayana is the supreme entity possessing unsurpassable auspicious attributes (*Uyarvara Uyarnalam*).
 - Saubhagya / Kripa*: The Lord grants *Bhakti-roopa-jnana* (wisdom matured into love) out of His own unconditional grace (*Mayarvara Madinalam Arulinan*).
 - Purushartha*: Eternal service (*Kainkaryam*) at His radiant feet (*Sudaradi Thozhuthezh*) is the ultimate goal of life.
- Commentarial Insights:** Nampillai, in his famed *Eedu 36000 Padi* commentary, notes that Nammalwar compressed the whole of the Brahmasutras into this single opening stanza. The word *Evanavan* ("He who is such") points to the Saguna Brahman of the Upanishads—not an abstract void, but a personal, infinitely loving God whose feet destroy all worldly afflictions (*Thuyararu Sudaradi*).

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- Physical Posture (Asana):** Seated in *Padmasana* (Lotus Posture) beneath the sacred Tamarind tree, exhibiting absolute tranquility.
- Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Right hand held in **Jnana Mudra** (index finger touching thumb, communicating supreme Vedantic truth), left hand holding palm-leaf manuscripts (*Grantha*) or resting on his lap.
- Garments & Embellishments:** Adorned with sacred *Vakula* (Mimusops elengi / Magizham) flower garlands, simple holy robes, and prominent *Urdhva Pundra* (white clay tilak) markings across twelve parts of his body.
- Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Alwarthirunagari, Nammalwar's *Moolavar* idol inside the Tamarind tree precinct presents an unforgettable image of divine serenity, portraying him as the eternal preceptor (*Acharya*) instructing the world.

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Nammalwar Tiruvaymoli Detailed Upanyasam Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Uyarvara Uyarsulum Pasuram Eedu Vyakhyanam Karunakarachariar"
- "Nammalwar Vaibhavam and Dravida Veda Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

5.3 Digital Text & Archival Links

- **Dravida Veda Repository:** <http://www.dravidaveda.org>
- **Project Madurai Texts:** <https://www.projectmadurai.org>
- **Koyil Archival Library:** <https://koyil.org>

2. MADHURAKAVI AZHWAR

(Chittiraiyil Chithirai Avatharam, Mathurakavigal, Azhwarkku Adiyaan)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Madhurakavi Azhwar, Mathurakavigal (The Sweet Singer/Poet), Azhwarkku Adiyaan (The Servant of Nammalwar), Foremost Disciple of Nammalwar.
- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Chittirai
 - **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Chithirai
 - **Tithi & Paksham:** Dvapara Yuga terminal phase / Early Kali Yuga; Sukla Paksha Navami.
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Thirukkolor (near Thirukkurugur)
 - **Current District & State:** Thoothukudi District, Tamil Nadu.
 - **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Vaithamanidhi Perumal Temple, Thirukkolor & Alwarthirunagari.
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**
 - **Divine Amsam:** Kumuda (The celestial attendant/garland aspect of Sriman Narayana).
 - **Historical Period:** c. 8th–9th Century CE.
 - **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Nammalwar (His Supreme Guru and sole Object of Worship).

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Birth & Vedic Education:** Born into a distinguished Brahmin family at Thirukkolor and mastering the Sanskrit Vedas → **Northern Pilgrimage:** Undertaking an extensive pilgrimage across Ayodhya, Mathura, Kashi, and Vrindavan → **The Celestial Light:** Spotting an extraordinary, blinding beam of light shining continuously toward the South → **Journey to Thirukkurugur:** Journeying southward thousands of miles following the divine beam → **Meeting Nammalwar:** Posing the immortal question to Nammalwar inside the Tamarind tree → **Exclusive Devotion (Acharya Bhakti):** Composing *Kanninun Siruthambu* and serving Nammalwar exclusively as God Himself → **Preservation of Works:** Recording and singing Nammalwar's *Tiruvaymoli* across Tamilakam before attaining eternal liberation.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born into a pious Vedic family in Thirukkolor, Madhurakavi mastered scripture at an early age. Driven by spiritual fervor, he traveled to Northern India on a grand pilgrimage to holy shrines including Ayodhya, Mathura, and Kashi. While residing in the North, he noticed a luminous pillar of light shining brightly in

the southern night sky. Intrigued by this supernatural phenomenon, which did not fade with sunrise, he resolved to follow its source.

- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** Madhurakavi's entire life purpose was transformed upon reaching Thirukkurugur. He discovered that the source of the divine light was sixteen-year-old Nammalwar, seated in total silence inside the hollow tamarind tree. Madhurakavi became Nammalwar's scribe, student, and personal servant. His specific *kainkaryam* was recording every verse sung by Nammalwar and propagating the *Tiruvaymoli* across the land.
- **Miracles & Historical Events:**
 1. *Following the Southern Light:* The miraculous light guided Madhurakavi over hundreds of leagues from Northern India directly to the Tamarind tree of Thirukkurugur, demonstrating that true spiritual seekers are divinely guided to their Acharya.
 2. *The Immutable Riddle:* Madhurakavi awakened Nammalwar from his sixteen-year silent trance by asking: "*If the small is born in the dead, what will it eat, and where will it stay?*" Nammalwar's profound response—"It will eat that and stay there"—revealed to Madhurakavi that Nammalwar was the living embodiment of divine wisdom.
 3. *Establishing Acharya Nishtai:* Madhurakavi composed eleven immortal verses known as *Kanninun Siruthambu*. Uniquely among all the Azhwars, Madhurakavi did not sing praise directly of Lord Narayana or any Divya Desam deity. Instead, he sang exclusively of his Guru, Nammalwar (*Shatagopan*). He declared: "*I know no other God than Shatagopa; singing his praise brings infinite bliss.*"
- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Madhurakavi represents the supreme paradigm of **Acharya Bhakti** (revering the Guru as higher than God Himself). He established the doctrine that surrender to the Acharya (*Acharya Abhimana Valli*) is superior even to direct surrender to the Supreme Lord (*Ekantha Prapatti*).
- **Attainment of Paramapadam:** After decades spent singing Nammalwar's glory and preserving his manuscripts for future generations, Madhurakavi ascended to Paramapadam, permanently occupying a place at the feet of Nammalwar.

💡 **Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: The Essence of Kanninun Siruthambu**

Kanninun Siruthambu holds a unique status in Sri Vaishnavism. It is considered the "master key" (*Chabi*) of the *Naalayira Divya Prabandham*. When Sri Nathamuni later sought to recover the lost 4,000 verses, he recited *Kanninun Siruthambu* 12,000 times with intense devotion at Alwarthirunagari, causing Nammalwar to appear before him in a vision and grant the entire Dravida Veda corpus.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works:**
 - *Kanninun Siruthambu* (11 Pasurams) – A sacred Tamil Prabandham dedicated entirely to Nammalwar.
- **Quantified Output:** 11 Pasurams.
- **Associated Divya Desams (Mangalasasanam):** Glorified Thirukkurugur (Alwarthirunagari) exclusively as the holy site of his Acharya's presence.

- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Established the fundamental doctrine of **Charama Parva Adhikara** (The Ultimate Stage of Devotion: serving the devotee of God, rather than God directly). He acted as the original archivist and propagator of Nammalwar's literary heritage.
- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core: Acharya-Nishta / Guru-Bhakti** (Unswerving, absolute absorption in the preceptor). His philosophical stance asserts that God is accessible only through the grace of the Acharya.

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Kanninun Siruthambu, Pasuram 2 (*Devu Matrariyen*)

Text Layer	Content
Original Script (<i>Tamil</i>)	தேவு மற்றறியேன் குருகூர்நம்பி பாவின் இன்னிசை பாடித்திரிவேனே மேவி நன்மணம் மேல்வர நோக்கியே நாவினாய் உய்யநான் கண்டு கொண்டெனே
Roman Transliteration	<i>Devu matrariyen Kurugur Nambi</i> <i>Pavin innisai padithirivene</i> <i>Mevi nanmanam melvara nokkiye</i> <i>Navinai uyyanan kundu kondene</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Devu: Deity/God; Matrariyen: I know no other; Kurugur Nambi: The Lord/Leader of Thirukkurugur (Nammalwar); Pavin: of his verses/hymns; Innisai: sweet musical melody; Padi: singing; Thirivene: I wander about joyfully; Mevi: seeking with desire; Nanmanam: noble spiritual fragrance/goodness; Melvara: rising up/increasing; Nokkiye: looking upon; Navinai: by my tongue; Uyya: for my soul's redemption; Nan: I; Kandu kondene: have discovered and held firm.

Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

1. **Esoteric Meaning (Swaroopā Jñanam):** Madhurakavi Azhwar makes a breathtaking theological assertion: "*Devu Matrariyen*"—"I know no other God except Nammalwar!" He openly proclaims that singing the melodious verses authored by his Acharya brings higher spiritual fulfillment than direct ritual worship of the Supreme Lord Narayana.
2. **Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Establishes the doctrine of *Bhagavata Seshatvam* (the ultimate nature of the soul is to be a servant of God's devotees). While *Bhagavad-Seshatvam* (servitude to God) is the middle state, servitude to the Acharya (*Acharya Seshatvam*) represents the absolute climax (*Charama Seema*) of spiritual maturity in Viśiṣṭādvaita.
3. **Commentarial Insights:** Manavala Mamunigal in his *Upadesa Rathnamalai* and Periyavachan Pillai in his commentaries declare that Madhurakavi Azhwar demonstrated the true spirit of *Prapatti*. By relying entirely on Nammalwar, he showed that the Acharya acts as the ultimate refuge (*Purushakara*) who guarantees salvation to the disciple.

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- **Physical Posture (Asana):** Standing or seated in *Anjali Mudra* (folded hands in humble supplication) facing Nammalwar.
- **Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Hands held continuously in prayer (*Anjali*) or holding palm leaves and a writing stylus (*Ezhuthanai*) used to record Nammalwar's utterances.
- **Garments & Embellishments:** Dressed in simple traditional Brahmin priestly attire (*Vesti*), with a sacred thread (*Yajnopavitam*), adorned with *Tulasi* beads and prominent *Urdhva Pundra* (tilak) marks.
- **Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Thirukkolur and Alwarthirunagari, Madhurakavi Azhwar's image is positioned perpetually at the feet of Nammalwar, reflecting his eternal stance as the dedicated servant of his master.

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Madhurakavi Azhwar Kanninun Siruthambu Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Devu Matrariyen Pasuram Detailed Vyakhyanam Karunakarachariar"
- "Acharya Bhakti and Madhurakavi Vaibhavam Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

5.3 Digital Text & Archival Links

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- **Koyil Archival Library:** <https://koyil.org>

3. KULASEKARA AZHWAR

(Kolli Kavalanh, Koodal Nayagan, Cheraman, Kulasekara Perumal, Mukundamala Kara)

Section 1: Identification & Incarnation Details

- **Full Name & Titles:** Kulasekara Azhwar, Kulasekara Perumal, Kolli Kavalan (Protector of the Kolli Hills), Koodal Nayagan, Cheraman, King Kulasekara, Author of Mukundamala.
- **Incarnation Metadata:**
 - **Tamil Month (Maasam):** Masi (Kumbham)

- **Birth Star (Nakshatram):** Punarvasu (Punarpoosam)
- **Tithi & Paksham:** Dvapara Yuga terminal phase / Early Medieval Era; Sukla Paksha Saptami.
- **Geographic Origins:**
 - **Historic Birthplace Name:** Thiruvanchikulam (Kodungallur / Mahodayapuram)
 - **Current District & State:** Thrissur District, Kerala.
 - **Associated Divya Desam / Temple:** Thiruvanchikulam, Thirunarrayur, Sri Rangam, Thiruvengadam (Tirupati), and Mannarkoil (near Ambasamudram, Tirunelveli).
- **Divine Lineage & Era:**
 - **Divine Amsam:** Kaustubham (The Divine Gem of Lord Narayana) / Divine Bow (*Sarnga* aspect).
 - **Historical Period:** Early Chera Dynasty Monarch (c. 8th–9th Century CE).
 - **Sovereign & Scholarly Contemporaries:** Chera, Chola, and Pandya contemporary rulers; scholars of Sri Rangam.

Section 2: Complete Life History & Miracles

2.1 Chronological Life Timeline

- **Royal Birth & Coronation:** Born as Prince to King Dridhavrata of the Chera Kingdom at Thiruvanchikulam and succeeding to the throne → **Military Conquests & Reign:** Ruling a vast realm as a brilliant warrior-king over the Chera, Chola, and Pandya regions → **Spiritual Awakening:** Listening to Ramayana discourses and falling into deep devotional trances (*Rama Bhakti*) → **The Test of the Snake in the Pot:** Proving the innocence of Vaishnava devotees accused of theft by putting his hand into a pot with a deadly cobra → **Renunciation of Royalty:** Abdicating his crown in favor of his son and departing for Sri Rangam → **Kainkaryam at Sri Rangam & Tirupati:** Composing *Perumal Thirumozhi* and *Mukundamala* → **Final Liberation:** Attaining Mukthi at Mannarkoil Sri Rajagopalaswamy Temple.

2.2 Deep Biographical Narrative

- **Early Years & Spiritual Awakening:** Born into the royal Chera dynasty, Kulasekara was educated in statecraft, martial arts, Sanskrit, and Tamil. Upon ascending the throne, he expanded his kingdom through successful military campaigns, earning titles like *Kolli Kavalan* and *Koodal Nayagan*. However, worldly conquest brought him no inner peace. He spent his nights listening to scholars recite the epics, particularly the *Srimad Ramayana*. His emotional immersion in Lord Rama's life was so intense that during recitations of the *Aranya Kanda*—when Rama faced 14,000 demons alone at Janasthana—Kulasekara would rise in a trance, assemble his royal army, and command a march to assist Rama in battle.
- **Core Seva / Kainkaryam:** Renouncing royal luxury to perform physical and literary service at holy shrines, particularly Sri Rangam and Thiruvengadam. He is celebrated for constructing the third enclosure wall (*Kulasekaran Thiruchutru*) at the Sri Rangam temple complex.
- **Miracles & Historical Events:**
 1. *The Snake in the Pitcher:* Kulasekara spent his wealth feeding and honoring Sri

Vaishnava saints in his palace. Jealous ministers, seeking to discredit the devotees, hid a valuable royal gem necklace and blamed the Vaishnavas. Indignant at this slander against God's servants, King Kulasekara ordered a copper pitcher containing a venomous cobra to be brought into open court. Proclaiming, "*No true servant of Narayana would ever commit theft!*", he fearlessly plunged his hand into the pitcher. The cobra refrained from biting him, completely vindicating the innocence of the devotees and shaming the corrupt ministers.

2. **Abdication & Departure:** Realizing that royal duties interfered with his spiritual life, Kulasekara abdicated his throne, crowned his son, and left his kingdom as a simple pilgrim bound for Sri Rangam.
3. **Longing for Thiruvengadam:** In his famous *Perumal Thirumozhi* (Decad 4), he expressed deep *Vairagya* (dispassion), singing that he desired no worldly power, royal wealth, or celestial pleasures. Instead, he prayed to be born on Tirumala hill as a bird, a fish in a holy stream, a stepping stone at the temple threshold, or a piece of stone upon which devotees step. To this day, the threshold leading into the sanctum sanctorum (*Garbhagriha*) of Lord Venkateswara at Tirupati is called the **Kulasekara Padi**.
- **Guru-Disciple Dynamics:** Reverted directly to Srīman Narayana and Lord Sri Rama as his ultimate refuge, serving as an inspirational model of royal renunciation for future Acharyas like Yamunacharya.
- **Attainment of Paramapadam:** After spending his final years in total devotion across Sri Rangam, Tirupati, and Thirukannapuram, he passed away at the age of sixty-seven at Mannarkoil (near Ambasamudram), merging into Lord Rajagopalaswamy.

💡 **Sthala Puranam & Legend Highlight: Kulasekara Padi & Sri Rangam Connection**

Kulasekara Azhwar's humility is immortalized in temple architecture across South India. The threshold step directly before the sanctum sanctorum of Lord Venkateswara at Tirupati, as well as in many other major temples, is called the *Kulasekara Padi*. Devotees step over this sacred threshold with deep reverence, honoring the king who chose to be a humble step for Lord Venkateswara's devotees rather than wear a royal crown.

Section 3: Literary, Preservation & Philosophical Contributions

- **Complete List of Works:**
 - *Perumal Thirumozhi* (105 Pasurams in Tamil) – Divided into 10 Decads covering intense *Rama Bhakti*, *Vatsalya Bhakti* (as Kausalya singing lullabies to Rama, and Yashoda lamenting Krishna's departure), and *Vairagya* at Tirumala.
 - *Mukundamala* (40 Slokas in elegant Sanskrit) – A classic devotional hymn sung across India praising Lord Mukunda/Narayana.
- **Quantified Output:** 105 Tamil Pasurams and 40 Sanskrit Slokas.
- **Associated Divya Desam (Mangalasasanam):** Sri Rangam, Thiruvengadam (Tirupati), Thirukannapuram, Thiruvithuvakkodu, Thiruchitrakootam (Chidambaram), Ayodhya.
- **Sampradaya Defense & Preservation:** Exemplified total dispassion (*Vairagya*) and proved that worldly power is utterly insignificant compared to devotional service

(*Kainkaryam*). Elevated *Saranagati* (surrender) through both Sanskrit and Tamil poetic traditions.

- **Predominant Bhakti Bhava & Philosophical Core: Vatsalya Bhakti** (Parental affection toward Rama/Krishna) and **Artha-Saranagati / Vairagya** (Uncompromising renunciation and surrender). His work emphasizes *Ananya-Gatitvam* (having no other refuge than God).

Section 4: Representative Verses & Theological Breakdown

Verse 1: Perumal Thirumozhi, Decad 4, Pasuram 9 (*Padiyay Kidanthu*)

Text Layer	Content
Original Script (<i>Tamil</i>)	செடியாய வல்வினைகள் தீர்க்கும் திருமாலே அடியார்வ் என் உள்ளத்து அசையாது இருப்பானே படியாய்க் கிடந்து உன் பவளவாய் காண்பேனே அடியார் உம் தேவரும் அல்லாரும் ஏத்தும் வேங்கடத்து என் அப்பானே !
Roman Transliteration	<i>Chediyaya valvinaigal theerkkum Thirumale</i> <i>Adiyar en ullathu asaiyathu iruppane</i> <i>Padiyay kidanthu un pavalavay kanbene</i> <i>Adiyar um devarum allarum etthum</i> <i>Vengadathu en appane!</i>
Literal Word-by-Word Meaning	Chediyaya: Like dense tangled thickets/bushes; Valvinaigal: strong past karmas/sins; Theerkkum: who eradicates/destroys; Thirumale: Oh Lord Narayana (consort of Sri Lakshmi); Adiyar: your devotees; En ullathu: in my heart; Asaiyathu: unshakeably/steadfastly;

	Iruppane: Oh Lord who resides; Padiyay kidanthu: lying down/remaining as a threshold step; Un pavalavay kanbene: so that I may gaze continuously upon your coral-red lips; Adiyar um: devotees; Devarum: celestial gods; Allarum: and all ordinary human beings; Etthum: praise and glorify; Vengadathu: presiding at Tirumala/Thiruvengadam; En appane: Oh my Father/Master!
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Exhaustive Theological & Philosophical Commentary:

1. **Esoteric Meaning (Swaroopam Jnanam):** Kulasekara Azhwar prays for the ultimate expression of spiritual humility: to become an inanimate threshold step (*Padi*) inside the sanctum of Thiruvengadam. In doing so, he can perpetually gaze upon the Lord's coral lips while receiving the touch of the dust from the feet of the Lord's visiting devotees (*Bhagavatas*).
2. **Viśiṣṭādvaita Alignment:** Represents the pinnacle of *Ananya-Seshatvam* (exclusive servitude) and *Bhagavata-Angikaram* (seeking proximity to devotees). The desire to be stepped upon by devotees highlights that service to God's servants (*Bhagavata Kainkaryam*) is the highest reward (*Purushartha*).
3. **Commentarial Insights:** Periyavachan Pillai in his commentary notes that while earthly kings seek exalted thrones (*Simhasanam*), King Kulasekara sought only to be a step (*Padi*). This verse gave birth to the term *Kulasekara Padi*, symbolizing the absolute eradication of ego (*Ahamkara-Nivritti*) required before entering God's presence.

Section 5: Visuals & Archival Resources

5.1 Iconography & Shrine Visual Description

- **Physical Posture (Asana):** Standing in royal yet humble posture with hands folded in *Anjali Mudra*, or seated wearing a royal crown while bearing devotional insignia.
- **Hand Gestures (Mudras):** Hands joined in *Anjali Mudra* at chest level; occasionally depicted holding his divine bow (*Sarnga*) alongside royal ornaments.
- **Garments & Embellishments:** Dressed in royal silk garments adorned with *Urdhva Pundra* (white clay tilak) markings, wearing a crown (*Kireetam*) and sacred *Tulasi* garlands over his royal jewels.
- **Avathara Sthalam Idol Description:** At Thiruvanchikulam and Mannarkoil, Kulasekara Azhwar's *Moolavar* icon presents a majestic combination of royal sovereignty and profound, tearful devotional humility.

5.2 Academic Audio/Video Lecture Queries

- "Kulasekara Azhwar Perumal Thirumozhi Upanyasam Velukkudi Krishnan"
- "Padiyay Kidanthu Un Pavalavay Kanbene Vyakhyanam Karunakarachariar"

- "Mukundamala and Kulasekara Vaibhavam Ananthapadmanabhachariar"

5.3 Digital Text & Archival Links

- **Dravida Veda Repository:** <http://www.dravidaveda.org>
- **Project Madurai Texts:** <https://www.projectmadurai.org>
- **Koyil Archival Library:** <https://koyil.org>